Market Size Forecasting

Data File Format — October 2026

This is what a spreadsheet must look like before the Market Size Forecasting page will forecast it. The page checks the file on upload and refuses to run if anything is wrong, so a file that passes this guide will model cleanly.

What the file needs

Two columns. One of dates, one of numbers. Nothing else is required, and any extra columns are ignored.

Date	Sales
2024-01-31	412,800
2024-02-29	388,100
2024-03-31	441,650

The first row must be the column headings. Column names are detected automatically — `Date`, `Month`, `Period` and `Sales`, `Revenue`, `Value` all work, and both can be overridden from a dropdown after upload if the page picks the wrong one.

Accepted file types: `.xlsx`, `.xls` and `.csv`.

Date formats

Any of these spellings is read correctly. Use **one style for the whole column** — a column that mixes two styles will have the minority rows rejected.

Style	Accepted examples
Full date	`2024-01-31` · `31/01/2024`
Month and year	`2024-01` · `Jan 2024` · `Jan-24` · `Dec '22` · `Dec'22`
Statistical	`2024M01` (as FRED and BLS publish)
Quarter	`Q1 2024` · `2024Q1` · `2024-Q1` · `Q1-2024`
Year only	`2024`

A label naming a period rather than a day — `Jan 2024`, say — is placed at the end of that period, so it lands on 31 January. The page reports how many rows it moved.

Frequency (weekly, monthly, quarterly, annual) is inferred from the spacing between your dates and sets the seasonal period. It can be overridden after upload.

Number formats

Values may be formatted for reading. All of these are understood:

Formatting	Example
Thousands separators	`1,234` · `1 234`
Currency symbols	`$1,234` · `£1,234` · `€1,234`
Percentages	`12.5%`
Accounting negatives	`(87)` read as −87

Leave a cell **empty** where there is no value. Do not write `n/a`, `-` or `NA` — those are text, and text in the value column cannot be forecast.

What breaks a file

One row covering two months

A label such as `Jan/Feb '23` — as China's National Bureau of Statistics publishes, combining January and February around Chinese New Year. A single figure covering two months cannot be placed in one month without distorting it. **Split the figure across two rows**, or relabel the row as the single period it represents.

Title or merged cells above the headings

The first row of the sheet must be the column names. A report title, a logo row or merged cells above them will be read as the headings.

Totals and subtotal rows

A "Total" or "FY2024" row mixed in with the periods is read as another period and distorts the series. Remove them before uploading.

Two date styles in one column

Mixing `2024-01-31` and `Jan '24` in the same column means the minority style is rejected. Pick one.

Repeated periods

Two rows for the same period are *combined* (summed) and the page tells you it happened. That is usually intended — but check it is.

Gaps

Missing periods are allowed and reported. They are treated as missing, not as zero. A long run of them weakens the forecast.

Minimum history

- **4 periods** — the least that will fit any model at all.
- **24 periods** — needed before SARIMAX will use the FRED macroeconomic indicators. Below that, SARIMAX is skipped and SARIMA and Prophet still run.

More history is better: the seasonal models need at least two full cycles to see a seasonal pattern, so two years of monthly data is a sensible floor and three or more is comfortable.

What happens if something is wrong

The page checks the file **before** offering to forecast it. If there is a problem, the *Run analysis* button does not appear and the page names what is wrong, which cells caused it, and what to change. Nothing is forecast from a file the page only half understood.

Problems that stop the run:

- Dates that cannot be read — the offending labels are listed by name
- A value column holding no numbers
- Fewer than four usable periods

Things the page tells you about but still runs:

- Repeated periods that were combined
- Periods with no value
- A series too short for SARIMAX

Before you send a file — quick check

- Row 1 is the column headings, nothing above it
- One date column, one value column
- One date style throughout
- No combined periods such as `Jan/Feb`
- No totals or subtotal rows
- Blank cells where data is missing, not `n/a`
- At least 24 periods if the macroeconomic drivers matter to you

*The same guidance is available inside the portal at any time — the **File format** button at the top of the Market Size Forecasting page.*